

Quality Report on International Trade Statistics

2010 edition

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1 Introduction

1.1 International trade statistics

International trade statistics, as produced by Eurostat, measure the value and quantity of goods traded between the Member States of the European Union (known as intra-EU trade or Intrastat) and goods traded by the Member States of the EU with third countries (known as extra-EU trade or Extrastat). They are the official harmonised source of information about imports, exports and trade balance of the EU and of its Member States as well as of the euro area.

As international trade forms an important part of the world economy, statistics on the trading of goods are therefore an instrument of primary importance for numerous public and private sector decision makers. For example, international trade statistics:

- enable Community authorities to prepare multilateral and bilateral negotiations within the framework of the common commercial policy;
- enable Community authorities to evaluate the progress of the Single Market and the integration of EU economies;
- constitute an essential source of information for balance of payments statistics, national accounts and economic studies;
- help EU companies to conduct market research and define their commercial strategy.

This list, which is not exhaustive, demonstrates the diversity of the users and of their needs.

1.2 Community legislation

Community legislation in the field of international trade statistics ensures that the statistics provided to Eurostat by the national statistical authorities of Member States are based on precise legal texts, directly applicable in the Member States, and on definitions and procedures which, to a large extent, have been harmonised.

Statistics relating to the trading of goods between Member States are based on Regulation (EC) No 638/2004 of the European Parliament and of the Council, and Commission Regulation (EC) No 1982/2004 and the amending Commission Regulation (EC) 1915/2005). Data are collected directly from trade operators as a consequence of the abolishment of customs control at the borders between the Member States. The reporting burden is reduced as far as possible: private individuals and small traders are exempted from any statistical obligations.

The statistics on the trade with third countries are based on the Council Regulation (EC) 1172/95, the Commission Regulation (EC) 1917/2000 and amending Commission Regulations EC 1669/2001, 179/2005 and 1949/2005. Extra-EU trade statistics data are issued from the customs declarations. Trade operators fulfilling their reporting obligations to the Customs authorities in a Member State are providing at the same occasion data used to compile trade statistics.

The legal basis for both intra- and extra-EU trade statistics were revised in 2009. The new Regulations (Regulation (EC) No 222/2009 of the European Parliament and of the Council and Regulation (EC) No 471/2009 of the European Parliament and of the Council, respectively) do not introduce major changes to the general concepts and principles but rather allow more simplification possibilities in intra-EU trade

and align the data extra-EU trade statistics with Modernised Customs Code. Both Regulations include also articles on standardised procedures for quality reporting.

1.3 Quality reports and indicators

Quality reporting is not a new concept in European trade statistics. Since 2005, the Intrastat legislation made annual reporting on determined quality indicators for international trade statistics mandatory. Member States have to supply Eurostat with an annual Quality Report in a fixed deadline after the reference year. In practice this reporting process has been harmonized: Member States fulfil their obligation of quality reporting by completing the national quality report pre-filled by Eurostat. The key quality indicators are then gathered in this summary Quality Report. The revised Extrastat legislation includes now also a similar article so the quality reporting procedure is harmonised over intra and extra-EU trade statistics.

This Summary Quality Report synthesizes the main results of the national quality reports. The figures and descriptions of methods refer to **year 2008**. The corresponding data for 2007 are shown in Annex.

2 Relevance

ESS Quality Definition

Relevance is the degree to which statistical outputs meet current and potential user needs. It depends on whether all the statistics that are needed are produced and the extent to which concepts used (definitions, classifications etc.) reflect user needs.

The EU trade statistics follow largely the international recommendations by United Nations Statistics Division (cf. International Merchandise Trade Statistics: Concepts and Definitions, 1998). This general recommendations manual is updated regularly so that it reflects the changes in the environment of international trade. Furthermore, the Intrastat and Extrastat Regulations as well as classifications for international trade are revised regularly in order to take into account the economic and administrative environment as well as users' needs.

International trade forms an important part of the world economy and, as such, must be measured reliably and the relevant statistical data should be comparable and widely disseminated. The statistics satisfy this need in a variety of ways. Users may need either very aggregated or very detailed data on products or partner countries. They may be interested in movements of values of trade in current prices or in movements of the volume of trade at constant prices. Alternatively, their interest may be in the weight of trade or some other quantity measure. These examples, which are far from exhaustive, show the diversity of the users and their requirements. Eurostat tries to meet these various needs and to adapt to the changing environment as the progression toward globalization, in particular, is becoming more and more important.

The EU trade statistics are based on the Community legislation which is directly applicable in the Member States. In particular, the legislation includes a clear and precise list of all the statistical variables to be provided by the Member States to Eurostat. All the mandatory variables – with minor exceptions - are provided by all the Member States.

3 Accuracy

ESS Quality Definition

The accuracy of statistical outputs in the general statistical sense is the degree of closeness estimates to the true values.

The accuracy of international trade statistics is affected in different ways by several factors:

- Coverage of data collection and methods to adjust non-collected data
- Measurement units
- Data revisions
- Confidentiality
- Control procedures

3.1 Coverage of data collection and methods to adjust non-collected data

3.1.1 Intra-EU trade

International trade statistics belong to census type of statistics where data from all units is collected according to an agreed definition. In order to reduce the burden on enterprises, particularly small and medium sized ones, the Intrastat system is designed in a way that the workload for providers of statistical information varies according to the amount of trade in which they are engaged. To achieve this, each Member State applies a system of thresholds to exempt traders completely from statistical reporting or to limit the information they need to report¹.

From the above follows that Intrastat data collection does not cover 100 % of Member States' trade with other EU Member States. However, in order to have complete trade coverage in trade statistics, the loss caused by the exemption threshold must be compensated with adjustments. Similarly, the loss of coverage due to late-response or non-response must be offset by means of adjustments.

Table 1 shows the share of collected data (detailed and simplified declarations) and estimated data (below the thresholds and for non-response), calculated in terms of trade value, in intra-EU trade.

¹ More details about the thresholds and their impact on the response burden are reported in chapter 9

Table 1: Share of collected data and adjustments for trade below the exemption threshold and non-response in intra-EU trade (share of total value)

MEMBER STATES	Collected data				Estimated data			
	Detailed declarations		Simplified declarations		Below the exemption threshold		Non response	
	Arrivals	Dispatch	Arrivals	Dispatches	Arrivals	Dispatches	Arrivals	Dispatches
Belgium	96.8%	97.7%	0.0%	0.0%			(*) 3.1%	(*) 2.3%
Bulgaria	97.6%	98.8%			1.5%	0.8%	0.9%	0.4%
Czech Republic	97.8%	96.7%	0.1%	0.0%	0.9%	1.1%	1.2%	2.2%
Denmark	84.5%	91.3%	0.2%	0.1%			(*) 15.3%	(*) 8.6%
Germany	95.8%	97.9%	0.1%	0.2%	2.4%	1.4%	1.6%	0.6%
Estonia	94.4%	94.5%			2.8%	2.7%	2.8%	2.7%
Ireland	63.4%	84.6%	33.0%	13.7%	2.8%	1.4%	0.9%	0.3%
Greece **	100.0%	100.0%						
Spain	97.8%	98.1%			1.6%	1.2%	0.6%	0.7%
France	98.5%	98.4%	1.0%	1.1%	0.4%	0.4%		
Italy	97.4%	97.7%	0.0%	0.0%	2.6%	2.3%		
Cyprus	99.0%	98.2%			1.0%	1.8%	0.0%	0.0%
Latvia	94.7%	95.0%			3.0%	2.3%	2.3%	2.7%
Lithuania	97.7%	98.3%			2.3%	1.7%	0.0%	0.0%
Luxembourg	96.1%	97.6%	2.8%	1.2%	0.9%	0.8%	0.2%	0.4%
Hungary	91.2%	93.5%	0.2%	0.1%	4.9%	2.8%	3.7%	3.5%
Malta **	100.0%	100.0%						
Netherlands	87.2%	92.1%	0.0%	0.0%	3.7%	2.3%	9.0%	5.6%
Austria	95.8%	97.7%	0.0%	0.0%	2.8%	1.1%	1.4%	1.3%
Poland	97.7%	97.9%			1.3%	1.3%	0.9%	0.7%
Portugal	91.2%	92.4%	3.4%	3.3%	2.8%	2.9%	2.6%	1.4%
Romania	96.6%	97.7%			2.1%	1.5%	1.4%	0.8%
Slovenia	97.7%	98.6%			2.3%	1.4%	0.0%	0.0%
Slovakia	84.7%	86.9%	9.2%	8.3%	3.6%	3.1%	2.5%	1.7%
Finland	96.2%	98.3%	0.0%	0.0%	3.6%	1.7%	0.2%	0.0%
Sweden	95.6%	97.8%			2.4%	1.9%	1.9%	0.4%
United Kingdom	95.7%	96.8%	0.0%	0.1%	2.4%	2.7%	1.9%	0.4%
EU-27	95.0%	96.4%	0.9%	0.6%	:	:	:	:

Note: The shares of detailed and simplified declarations in EU-27 trade correspond to weighted averages. Member States' data are weighted by their respective total trade values. The share of estimated data refers to the share in the final figures transmitted to Eurostat. This share is usually larger in the intermediate data.

: Data not available

*: Only total level of adjustments (no distinction into below the exemption threshold and non-response) is available in Eurostat or the figures provided by the given MS in the national quality report do not match with the data.

**: No adjustment is compiled for trade below the exemption threshold and non response.

Table 2 shows the methods to compile adjustments and the level of adjusted data. For most Member States, adjustment methods are based on VAT data and/or historical data. According to the Intrastat legislation, the breakdown of adjustments transmitted to Eurostat must be at least by 2-digit product codes of the Harmonised System (HS2) and partner countries. A majority of Member States follow this requirement while some apply even more detailed breakdowns by products.

Table 2: Method and level of adjustments in intra-EU trade

MEMBER STATES	Adjustment for trade below the exemption threshold	Adjustment for non response	Level of adjustment
Belgium	Adjustment based on VAT data	Adjustment based on VAT data and trend indicator system for rapid estimates	CN8 / partner countries
Bulgaria	Adjustment based on historical figures	Adjustment based on historical figures and VAT data	HS2 / partner countries
Czech Republic	Adjustment based on VAT data	Adjustment based on historical figures	CN8 / partner countries
Denmark	Adjustment based on VAT data	Adjustment based on VAT data	CN8 / partner countries
Germany	Adjustment based on VAT data	Adjustment based on VAT data	HS2 / partner countries
Estonia	Adjustment based on historical figures and VAT data	Adjustment based on historical figures and VAT data	HS2 / partner countries
Ireland	Adjustment based on VAT data (use of the VAT return for the period in question or forecast done by applying the Holt-Winter's method)	Adjustment based on historical figures (use of the Holt-Winter's method) or, failing that, on VAT data	Below the threshold: by partner only Non response: CN8/ partner countries
Greece	No adjustment	No adjustment	
Spain	Adjustment based on VAT data	Adjustment based on historical figures	HS2 / partner countries
France	Adjustment based on VIES data	Adjustment based on historical figures	HS2 / partner countries
Italy	Adjustment based on “just-above-the-threshold” traders	No adjustment since the survey is total and the obligation of reporting is fiscal.	HS2 / partner countries
Cyprus	Adjustment based on VAT data	Adjustment based on historical figures (use of the Holt-Winter's method or, if not applicable, of the average of previous actual returns) or, if not applicable, on VAT data	CN8 / partner countries
Latvia	Adjustment based on historical figures and VAT data when available	Adjustment based on historical figures and VAT data when available	HS2 / partner countries
Lithuania	Adjustment based on VAT data	Adjustment based on VAT data	HS2 / partner countries
Luxembourg	Adjustment based on historical figures and VAT data (together with adjustment for non-response)	Adjustment based on historical figures and VAT data (together with adjustment for trade below the threshold)	HS2 / partner countries
Hungary	Adjustment based on VAT data	Adjustment based on historical figures and VAT data	HS4 / partner countries
Malta	No adjustment because a very low threshold	No adjustment	
Netherlands	Adjustment based on VAT data	Adjustment is based on historical figures and VAT data	HS2 / partner countries
Austria	Adjustment based on VAT data	Adjustment based on VAT data for non response and historical data for late response	CN8 / partner countries
Poland	Adjustment based on historical figures and VAT data	Adjustment based on historical figures and VAT data	CN8 / partner countries
Portugal	Adjustment based on VAT data	Adjustment based on common respondents	By HS2 / No partner breakdown
Romania	Adjustment based on historical figures and fiscal data (VAT & VIES)	Adjustment based on historical figures and fiscal data (VAT & VIES)	HS4 / partner countries
Slovenia	Adjustment based on VAT data	Adjustment based on historical figures and VAT data	CN8 / partner countries
Slovakia	Adjustment based on historical figures and VAT data	Adjustment based on historical figures and VAT data	CN8 / partner countries
Finland	Adjustment based on VAT data	Adjustment based on historical figures and VAT data	HS2 / partner countries
Sweden	Adjustment based on historical figures and VAT data	Adjustment based on imputation or growth models using historical figures or VAT data	HS2 / partner countries
United Kingdom	Adjustment based on VAT data	Adjustment based on growth factors	Below the threshold: By CN8 codes and partners Non response: No product or partner breakdown

3.1.2 Extra-EU trade

The problem of non-response for extra-EU trade should theoretically not exist since extra-EU trade statistics are based on customs declarations. Nevertheless, adjustments for "late" response may be necessary as well as adjustments for trade below the thresholds when an exemption threshold is applied.

Table 3: Share of collected data and adjustments for trade below the exemption threshold and late-response in extra-EU trade (share of total value)

MEMBER STATES	Collected data		Estimated data			
	Standard category		Below the exemption threshold		Late/partial response	
	Imports	Exports	Imports	Exports	Imports	Exports
Belgium	100.0%	100.0%				
Bulgaria	100.0%	100.0%				
Czech Republic	100.0%	100.0%				
Denmark	100.0%	100.0%	0.0%			
Germany	99.8%	99.7%	0.2%	0.3%		
Estonia	100.0%	100.0%				
Ireland	100.0%	99.9%		0.1%		
Greece	100.0%	100.0%				
Spain	100.0%	100.0%				
France	99.4%	99.4%	0.6%	0.6%		
Italy	99.7%	99.2%	0.3%	0.8%		
Cyprus	100.0%	100.0%				
Latvia	100.0%	100.0%				
Lithuania	100.0%	100.0%				
Luxembourg	100.0%	100.0%				
Hungary	100.0%	100.0%				
Malta	100.0%	100.0%				
Netherlands	99.5%	98.4%			0.5%	1.6%
Austria	100.0%	99.9%	0.0%	0.1%		
Poland	100.0%	100.0%				
Portugal	100.0%	100.0%				
Romania	100.0%	100.0%				
Slovenia	99.9%	99.9%	0.1%	0.1%		
Slovakia	100.0%	100.0%				
Finland	100.0%	100.0%				
Sweden	100.0%	100.0%				
United Kingdom	98.8%	99.4%	1.2%	0.6%		
EU-27	99.6%	99.6%	0.3%	0.3%	0.1%	0.1%

The methods to compile adjustments and level of adjusted data for extra-EU trade are shown in table 4. The Extrastat legislation requires Member States to adjust data if statistical thresholds are applied. The adjustment should be available at least for the total products. Most Member States do not make adjustments because of low thresholds or no threshold at all.

Table 4: Method and level of adjustments in extra-EU trade

MEMBER STATES	Method of adjustment	Level of adjustment
Belgium	No adjustment	
Bulgaria	No adjustment	
Czech Republic	No adjustment	
Denmark	Adjustment based on control unit price limits to identify the declarations where only the net value added has been reported (allowed in imports after outward processing)	CN8 / partner countries
Germany	Adjustment based on fixed factor generated on basis of the value structure of former threshold raises	HS2 / No partner breakdown
Estonia	No adjustment	
Ireland	Estimations made for parcel post	No product or partner breakdown For a few cases, by partner country
Greece	No adjustment	
Spain	No adjustment	
France	Adjustment based on data collected by Customs	No product or partner breakdown
Italy	Adjustment based on data collected by Customs	No product or partner breakdown
Cyprus	No adjustment	
Latvia	No adjustment	
Lithuania	No adjustment	
Luxembourg	No adjustment	
Hungary	No adjustment	
Malta	No adjustment	
Netherlands	Adjustment based on historical data	HS2 / partner countries
Austria	Adjustment based on yearly updated factors derived from a statistical regression analysis taking into account the distribution of classified transaction values close above the threshold	No product or partner breakdown
Poland	No adjustment	
Portugal	No adjustment	
Romania	No adjustment	
Slovenia	Adjustment based on data collected by Customs for statistical purposes	No product or partner breakdown
Slovakia	No adjustment	
Finland	No adjustment	
Sweden	No adjustment	
United Kingdom	Adjustment based on data collected by Customs	No product or partner breakdown

3.2 Measurement units

3.2.1 Statistical value

International trade statistics apply harmonised principles when compiling the statistical value of trade flows. In general all goods should be valued with the total amount which would be invoiced in case of sale or purchase at the national border of the reporting Member State. In practice the statistical value of the good is based in most of the cases for intra-EU trade on the taxable amount determined for VAT purposes and for extra-EU trade on the value determined for customs purposes.

The statistical value does not include taxes on export or import, such as customs duties, value added tax, excise duty, levies, export refunds or other taxes with similar effect. It includes only incidental expenses (freight, insurance) incurred, in the case of exports/dispatches, in the part of the journey located on the territory of the reporting Member State and, in the case of imports/arrivals, in the part of the journey located outside the territory of the reporting Member State. It is said to be a FOB value (free on board), for exports/dispatches, and a CIF value (cost, insurance, freight) for imports/arrivals.

In intra-EU trade, the statistical value is not provided systematically by the information providers (see chapter 9). It usually differs from the amount agreed on the sales agreement (the invoice value) as a result of the delivery terms used in the transaction; therefore the statistical value must be collected in connection with the invoice value or must be estimated by using other variables such as delivery terms and mode of transport.

The quantitative impact of calculating the statistical value is shown in table 5. For most Member States it is relatively small.

Table 5: The quantitative impact of calculating the statistical value

MEMBER STATES	Arrivals	Dispatches
Belgium	No adjustment	No adjustment
Bulgaria	1.4%	-0.1%
Czech Republic	0.2%	-0.6%
Denmark	:	:
Germany	0.0%	0.4%
Estonia	1.1%	-0.5%
Ireland	:	:
Greece	:	:
Spain	-0.1%	-0.2%
France	-0.1%	-0.5%
Italy	1.8%	-0.3%
Cyprus	3.3%	-3.0%
Latvia	1,3%	-0,7%
Lithuania	1.5%	-0.2%
Luxembourg	2.5%	-2.1%
Hungary	-0.3%	0.0%
Malta	:	:
Netherlands	:	:
Austria	0.1%	-0.4%
Poland	0.6%	-0.4%
Portugal	:	:
Romania	0.8%	-0.2%
Slovenia	0.4%	-0.6%
Slovakia	1.4%	-0.7%
Finland	1.6%	-2.3%
Sweden	1.1%	-1.0%
United Kingdom	0.3%	-0.5%

: Data not available

As table 6 shows, most Member States collect statistical value from the trade operators above the statistical value threshold only and then estimate it for trade operators which remain below this threshold. On the other hand, some Member States do not collect statistical value at all but carry out adjustments on the invoice value in order to estimate it.

Table 6: Methods adopted for calculating the statistical value in intra-EU trade

MEMBER STATES	Method of adjustment
Belgium	Statistical value not collected at all. No adjustment, use of the invoice value.
Bulgaria	Statistical value collected from trade operators above the threshold only. Correcting coefficient computed from historical data.
Czech Republic	Statistical value not collected at all. Correcting coefficient computed from historical data.
Denmark	Statistical value not collected at all. Adjustment from invoice value to statistical value done by applying factors derived from a survey.
Germany	Statistical value collected from trade operators above the threshold only. Correcting coefficient computed from above the threshold data for trade data below the threshold.
Estonia	Statistical value collected from trade operators above the threshold only. Correcting coefficient computed from above the threshold data for trade data below the threshold
Ireland	Statistical value collected from trade operators above the threshold only. Use of invoice value for trade data below the threshold.
Greece	Statistical value collected from trade operators above the threshold but as well below the threshold. Therefore, no adjustment is needed.
Spain	Statistical value collected from trade operators above the threshold only. Use of invoice value for trade data below the threshold.
France	Statistical value not collected at all. Correcting coefficient computed from historical data.
Italy	Statistical value collected from trade operators above the threshold only. Correcting coefficient computed from above the threshold data for trade data below the threshold.
Cyprus	Statistical value collected from trade operators above the threshold only. Correcting coefficient computed from above the threshold data for trade data below the threshold.
Latvia	Statistical value collected from trade operators above the threshold only. Correcting coefficient computed from historical data for trade data below the threshold.
Lithuania	Statistical value collected from trade operators above the threshold only. Use of invoice value for trade data below the threshold.
Luxembourg	Statistical value collected from trade operators above the threshold only. Correcting coefficient computed from above the threshold data for trade data below the threshold.
Hungary	Statistical value collected from trade operators above the threshold only. Use of invoice value for trade data below the threshold.
Malta	No adjustment since both invoice and statistical values are collected.
Netherlands	Statistical value not collected at all. Correcting coefficients derived from historical data.
Austria	Statistical value collected from trade operators above the threshold only. Use of invoice value for trade data below the threshold.
Poland	Statistical value collected from trade operators above the threshold only. Correcting coefficient computed from above the threshold data for trade data below the threshold.
Portugal	Statistical value collected from trade operators above the threshold only. Correcting coefficient computed from above the threshold data for trade data below the threshold.
Romania	Statistical value collected from trade operators above the threshold only. Correcting coefficient computed from above the threshold data for trade data below the threshold.
Slovenia	Statistical value collected from trade operators above the threshold only. Use of invoice value for trade data below the threshold.
Slovakia	Statistical value not collected at all. Adjustment from invoice value to statistical value done by applying factors derived from a survey on ancillary costs carried out quarterly.
Finland	Statistical value collected from trade operators above the threshold only. Correcting coefficient computed from above the threshold data for trade data below the threshold.
Sweden	Statistical value not collected at all. Adjustment from invoice value to statistical value done by applying factors derived from a survey.
United Kingdom	Statistical value not collected at all. Delivery terms are collected from the largest traders. Adjustment from invoice value to statistical value done by a model using ancillary cost information derived from a monthly survey.

In extra-EU trade, the statistical value is based on customs value; therefore there is generally no need to adjust it.

3.2.2 Net mass

The quantity of a commodity is documented essentially in kilograms. This is the intrinsic weight of the commodity. It is defined as the weight of the commodity without any packing (net mass). However, some Member States do not transmit anymore the net mass when the supplementary unit is collected for intra-trade statistics as from 2006.

3.2.3 Supplementary unit

For selected types of commodities the quantity is also recorded and documented in a supplementary unit as this furnishes further useful information (e.g. Carats, Gross Tonnage, Kilowatt Hours, Litre, Square Metre, Cubic Metre, Number of Items, Terajoule). Further information whether a supplementary unit is collected for a given good is available in the Combined Nomenclature.

3.3 Revisions

Data are revised frequently according to national needs and practices. They become normally final from six months up to more than one year after the reference year. Revisions to older data are also possible.

Table 7 presents the impact of revisions in terms of trade value. Signs are indicative of the direction of this impact. Negative signs state higher first figure whereas positive signs indicate smaller first figure than last one. From table 7 follows that, in most of the cases there is an underestimation of the first transmitted figure. The average extent of the revisions is generally higher for intra-EU trade than for extra-EU trade, and is also higher for arrivals than for dispatches.

Table 7: Impact of revisions (in %) on detailed intra- and extra-EU trade

MEMBER STATES	Intra-EU trade		Extra-EU trade	
	Arrivals	Dispatches	Imports	Exports
Belgium	-2.7%	-1.9%	4.4%	12.9%
Bulgaria	-0.6%	-0.7%	-1.3%	0.0%
Czech Republic	1.2%	1.0%	1.3%	0.8%
Denmark	-2.7%	-0.8%	3.1%	0.8%
Germany	-2.6%	-1.6%	0.4%	-0.1%
Estonia	1.1%	1.4%	-0.9%	0.1%
Ireland	1.6%	0.5%	1.6%	3.8%
Greece	2.6%	2.7%	37.3%	0.7%
Spain	10.2%	7.3%	-0.2%	1.2%
France	2.0%	2.7%	0.2%	0.0%
Italy	2.4%	1.5%	0.0%	-0.1%
Cyprus	1.8%	5.6%	2.9%	-1.5%
Latvia	3.7%	2.9%	0.0%	0.0%
Lithuania	3.8%	0.0%	0.0%	0.0%
Luxembourg	1.9%	-1.5%	5.0%	9.5%
Hungary	3.6%	2.5%	0.2%	-0.1%
Malta	5.7%	7.1%	1.4%	4.3%
Netherlands	-0.9%	1.2%	3.6%	-0.8%
Austria	2.7%	2.4%	4.5%	0.0%
Poland	10.8%	8.1%	-1.6%	-3.6%
Portugal	2.6%	1.1%	-0.3%	0.3%
Romania	5.1%	2.2%	0.2%	0.1%
Slovenia	1.4%	0.2%	1.1%	0.2%
Slovakia	2.8%	0.4%	-0.3%	-0.1%
Finland	5.3%	0.6%	0.7%	1.7%
Sweden	2.4%	2.4%	1.6%	1.2%
United Kingdom	1.8%	2.0%	-1.7%	0.1%
EU-27	1.3%	1.0%	1.2%	0.8%

-: First figure>Last figure

+: First figure<Last figure

3.4 Confidentiality

The application of confidentiality has an impact on the accuracy, in particular at the most detailed level, as some characteristics are not shown at all or are available only at more aggregated level of data.

There are three types of confidentiality:

- Partner Confidentiality: in order to conceal the destination or the source or origin of a product, the code of the partner country is replaced by a 'secret country code', different for intra- and extra-EU trade.
- Product confidentiality: in order to suppress the nature of the commodity involved, all or part of the trade is allocated to a confidential product code. Information about a product may be regarded as commercially sensitive either for the value, the quantity or their ratio, since it would give an indication of the price of the product.
- Product and Partner Confidentiality: the two preceding types are applied at the same time; therefore both the partner and the product are hidden.

The levels of these three types of confidentiality can be assessed using data available in Eurostat Comext database, where special codes are used for hiding partner or product. Confidentiality can concern either value or quantity variables (net mass and supplementary quantity) or both measurement units. Table 8 shows the impact of confidentiality over total trade, in terms of trade value, net mass and number of 8-digit product codes (CN8) affected. As can be noticed, the importance of confidentiality is very different depending on the kind of trade, on the flow and on the Member State.

It should also be noticed that the shares have been calculated for confidentiality at total product level only; the picture would be different if we were considering a more disaggregated product level, for example the chapters.

Table 8: Impact of the confidentiality on intra- and extra-EU trade

MEMBER STATES	Intra-EU trade						Extra-EU trade					
	Arrivals			Dispatches			Imports			Exports		
	Number of CN8 codes affected	Impact on trade value (%)	Impact on net mass (%)	Number of CN8 codes affected	Impact on trade value (%)	Impact on net mass (%)	Number of CN8 codes affected	Impact on trade value (%)	Impact on net mass (%)	Number of CN8 codes affected	Impact on trade value (%)	Impact on net mass (%)
Belgium	40	0.7%	0.5%	131	1.9%	2.9%	43	2.2%	1.3%	126	3.2%	3.9%
Bulgaria												
Czech	586	0.1%	0.1%	233	0.6%	0.3%	348	0.4%	0.1%	213	0.9%	0.5%
Denmark	36	0.7%	1.4%	95	9.5%	4.9%	32	3.7%	1.5%	95	10.8%	13.1%
Germany	48	2.1%	6.0%	396	3.3%	7.1%	69	7.7%	24.4%	385	3.4%	9.6%
Estonia												
Ireland	14	0.0%	0.0%	6	0.0%	0.4%						
Greece	12	0.2%	0.0%	11	2.8%	0.7%	11	0.0%	0.0%	12	1.5%	0.4%
Spain	40	0.2%	0.3%	22	0.3%	0.7%	33	0.3%	0.2%	38	1.3%	1.1%
France	11	0.0%	0.0%	300	2.6%	4.5%	10	0.1%	5.4%	273	1.9%	4.1%
Italy	28	1.8%	0.2%	112	0.7%	1.2%	25	11.3%	18.5%	105	0.6%	1.1%
Cyprus	1	0.4%	0.0%				1	0.4%	0.0%			
Latvia												
Lithuania												
Luxembourg	2	4.3%	5.0%	7	1.1%	1.0%	1	1.3%	1.4%	5	2.0%	0.1%
Hungary	1 604	2.6%	5.8%	2 003	5.5%	15.0%	640	15.2%	37.2%	1 614	5.2%	16.3%
Malta												
Netherlands	206	4.7%	1.0%	489	8.2%	1.8%	277	5.8%	0.9%	835	6.2%	2.8%
Austria	96	2.1%	7.5%	260	6.8%	12.3%	89	12.0%	43.8%	260	6.9%	6.3%
Poland	1	0.0%	0.0%									
Portugal	3 843	1.4%	1.3%	1 203	5.2%	7.9%	1 457	1.6%	0.9%	1 097	4.2%	4.6%
Romania	85	0.2%	0.0%	49	0.2%	0.0%	74	0.2%	0.0%	42	0.5%	0.0%
Slovenia	25	0.1%	0.0%	10	0.0%	0.1%	23	0.1%	0.0%	20	0.2%	0.8%
Slovakia	1 031	0.2%		1 624	1.7%		88	0.1%		359	0.3%	
Finland	76	1.2%	10.1%	138	7.2%	14.8%	65	6.2%	11.0%	129	6.6%	14.4%
Sweden	18	0.1%	0.1%	83	3.3%	1.3%	15	0.6%	1.0%	83	5.3%	2.5%
United	21	0.1%	2.0%	76	1.2%	2.0%	39	0.5%	0.6%	71	0.8%	1.8%

Tables 9 and 10 split the share of confidential data into partner confidentiality, product confidentiality and simultaneously partner and product confidentiality, in terms of trade value and number of CN8 codes affected. As can be noticed, for most of the Member States, product confidentiality seems to affect rather more the dispatches/exports than the arrivals/imports. Moreover, some Member States are systematically only using one kind of confidentiality.

Table 9: Impact of different type of confidentiality on intra- and extra-EU trade (share of total value)

MEMBER STATES	Intra-EU trade (%)						Extra-EU trade (%)					
	Arrivals			Dispatches			Imports			Exports		
	Secret product	Secret partner	Product and partner	Secret product	Secret partner	Product and partner	Secret product	Secret partner	Product and partner	Secret product	Secret partner	Product and partner
Belgium	0.7%			1.9%			2.1%		0.0%	2.9%		0.3%
Bulgaria												
Czech Republic		0.1%	0.0%		0.6%	0.0%		0.3%	0.0%		0.6%	0.3%
Denmark	0.3%	0.4%		5.0%	4.5%		3.4%	0.3%		2.7%	8.1%	
Germany	0.1%		2.0%	2.4%		0.9%	0.1%	0.0%	7.7%	3.2%		0.3%
Estonia												
Ireland			0.0%			0.0%						
Greece	0.2%			2.8%			0.0%			1.5%		
Spain	0.2%			0.3%			0.3%			1.3%		
France	0.0%	0.0%		2.5%	0.0%	0.0%	0.0%	0.0%		1.9%	0.0%	0.0%
Italy			1.8%			0.7%			11.3%			0.6%
Cyprus			0.4%						0.4%			
Latvia												
Lithuania												
Luxembourg			4.3%			1.1%			1.3%			2.0%
Hungary	2.6%			5.5%			15.2%			5.2%		
Malta												
Netherlands	1.0%	0.3%	3.5%	1.0%	0.4%	6.9%	0.2%	0.6%	5.0%	1.3%	0.7%	4.2%
Austria	0.5%		1.6%	2.9%		3.9%	1.3%	10.7%		4.4%	2.5%	
Poland		0.0%										
Portugal	0.8%		0.5%	2.6%		2.6%	0.3%		1.3%	0.8%		3.4%
Romania	0.2%			0.2%			0.2%			0.5%		
Slovenia			0.1%			0.0%			0.1%			0.2%
Slovakia	0.2%			1.7%			0.1%	0.0%		0.3%		
Finland		0.5%	0.8%		1.9%	5.3%		0.1%	6.1%		2.0%	4.6%
Sweden			0.1%			3.3%			0.6%			5.3%
United Kingdom	0.1%	0.1%		1.1%	0.1%		0.3%	0.3%		0.6%	0.2%	

Table 10: Number of CN8 codes affected according to the type of confidentiality

MEMBER STATES	Intra-EU trade (%)						Extra-EU trade (%)					
	Arrivals			Dispatches			Imports			Exports		
	Secret product	Secret partner	Product and partner	Secret product	Secret partner	Product and partner	Secret product	Secret partner	Product and partner	Secret product	Secret partner	Product and partner
Belgium	40			131			32		11	116		10
Bulgaria												
Czech Republic		578	8		225	8		340	8		204	9
Denmark	21	15		53	42		17	15		52	43	
Germany	21		27	367		29	22	7	40	368		17
Estonia												
Ireland			14			6						
Greece	12			11			11			12		
Spain	40			22			33			38		
France	5	6		294	4	2	4	6		268	3	2
Italy			28			112			25			105
Cyprus			1						1			
Latvia												
Lithuania												
Luxembourg			2			7			1			5
Hungary	1 604			2 003			640			1 614		
Malta												
Netherlands	86	98	22	187	279	23	74	182	21	143	661	31
Austria	46		50	165		95	38	51		164	96	
Poland		1										
Portugal	2 182		1 661	568		635	543		914	236		861
Romania	85			49			74			42		
Slovenia			25			10			23			20
Slovakia	1 031			1 624			87	1		359		
Finland		38	38		12	126		36	29		12	117
Sweden			18			83			15			83
United Kingdom	8	13		58	18		10	29		43	28	

3.5 Control procedures

The prime responsibility for ensuring the accuracy of the published trade data rests with Member States as they are responsible for data collection and thus have the access to the detailed data. The control procedures can be broadly classified as:

- Controls of data validity: A validity error means that incorrect data causes processing problems, it cannot be included in the statistical analysis and so it must be removed or corrected. Examples of this kind of errors are incorrect or missing codes, missing values in the declarations; character data in numeric field and vice versa, etc. All Member States use reference tables with an automatic process to control these errors.
- Controls of data credibility: The data can be valid according to the previous criterion of validity but it is possibly incorrect; therefore it can be processed but it will distort the statistical analysis. The declaration for example is inconsistent internally in the comparison of the different variables, or it is not consistent with what was submitted in the previous months. The methods used by the Member States consist of checking one variable against the other within the declaration or between declarations.
- Controls of data completeness: These refer to controlling whether the reported trade data represents the complete trade of the given trader. In intra-EU data, a close link with the VAT system allows Member States to check data with the VAT declarations. In extra-EU trade, data are collected through Customs declarations so they are considered to be complete. Additional sources can also be used, for example data from other statistical domains or mirror statistics.

In addition, data are validated at Eurostat before loading into Comext database. This concern mainly controls of data validity. Further controls of data credibility and completeness are done for data already loaded into Comext, on the basis of internal studies or user feedback.

It should be kept in mind that, as basic data consists of millions of detailed trade declarations or reports each month, it is difficult to reach complete accuracy for the published statistics. As in all statistical work, a balance has to be struck between the resources devoted to checking and the likely benefit. Therefore the users should be aware of the margin of inaccuracies in the data used, at least concerning the most detailed level of data. This is particularly emphasised in the intra-EU trade statistics where smallest traders are exempted from making Intrastat declarations on their monthly trade (see chapter 9 for more details).

4 Timeliness and punctuality

ESS Quality Definition

The timeliness of statistical outputs is the length of time between the event or phenomenon they describe and their availability. Punctuality is the time lag between the release date of data and the target date on which they were scheduled for release as announced in an official release calendar, laid down by Regulations or previously agreed among partners.

First results (including estimates) on Euro area and EU trade balances are published on line around 48 days after the reference month in the international trade Euro-indicators news release. The latest supplied detailed data (updates and revisions) are published at the date of the monthly press release. Short term indicators are updated on a monthly basis at the date of the press release. They include all data published in the Euro-indicators news release. Long term indicators are updated generally once a year when complete results are available for the last reference year.

According to the Intrastat and Extrastat legislations, Member States should provide Eurostat with intra- and extra-EU aggregated statistics within 40 days after the reference month. For detailed statistics the deadlines are 42 days for extra-EU statistics and 70 days for intra-EU statistics.

Table 11 shows how each Member State complied with these requirements. The table shows how many times (out of the 12 months of the year 2008) intra- and extra-EU detailed or aggregated data was delivered late and what the average delay of these late deliveries was. This indicator is based on the dates when the first version of each monthly data is sent to Eurostat and it is compared with the legal deadlines.

Table 11: Transmission of detailed and aggregated results

MEMBER STATES	Aggregated data		Detailed data			
	Intra- and extra-EU trade		Intra-EU trade		Extra-EU trade	
	Number of delayed data deliveries	Average delay in number of days	Number of delayed data deliveries	Average delay in number of days	Number of delayed data deliveries	Average delay in number of days
Belgium	1	1 day(s)	1	4 day(s)	2	2 day(s)
Bulgaria					1	1 day(s)
Czech Republic						
Denmark	1	4 day(s)	3	2 day(s)	2	2 day(s)
Germany						
Estonia						
Ireland	1	1 day(s)				
Greece					1	1 day(s)
Spain	1	2 day(s)				
France						
Italy	1	3 day(s)	1	1 day(s)	1	1 day(s)
Cyprus						
Latvia						
Lithuania						
Luxembourg						
Hungary						
Malta						
Netherlands	1	3 day(s)				
Austria						
Poland					1	1 day(s)
Portugal						
Romania			1	1 day(s)		
Slovenia						
Slovakia						
Finland	1	4 day(s)				
Sweden						
United Kingdom						

5 Accessibility and Clarity

ESS Quality Definition

The accessibility of statistical outputs is the measure of the ease with which users can obtain the data. It is determined by the physical conditions by means of which users obtain data: where to go, how to order, delivery time, pricing policy, marketing conditions (copyright, etc.), availability of micro or macro data, various formats (paper, files, CD-ROM, Internet, etc).

The clarity of statistical outputs is the measure of the ease with which users can understand the data. It is determined by the information environment within which the data are presented, whether the data are accompanied with appropriate metadata, whether use is made of illustrations such as graphs and maps, whether information on data accuracy are available (including any limitations on use) and the extent to which additional assistance is provided by the producer.

All the different dissemination channels are used in dissemination: electronic and paper publications, predefined tables, databases, DVDs and FTP addresses for bulk download. Data are disseminated simultaneously and free of charges to all interested parties through Eurostat's website.

The dissemination of the international trade statistics is supported by a complete set of structural metadata making possible to easily identify, retrieve and browse the data. The reference metadata describing the contents and the data quality are as well exhaustive. User support is ensured by the help desk on Comext database.

6 Coherence and Comparability

ESS Quality Definition

The coherence of two or more statistical outputs refers to the degree to which the statistical processes by which they were generated used the same concepts – classifications, definitions and target populations – and harmonised methods. Coherent statistical outputs have the potential to be validly combined and used jointly. Examples of joint use are where the statistical outputs refer to the same population, reference period and region but comprise different sets of data items (say, employment data and production data) or where they comprise the same data items (say, employment data) but for different reference periods, regions or domains. Comparability is a special case of coherence and refers to the latter example above where the statistical outputs refer to the same data items and the aim of combining them is to make comparisons over time, or across regions, or across other domains.

6.1 Comparability over space

6.1.1 Comparability between EU international trade statistics and those of its main partners

There are two main approaches used for the measurement of international trade in goods, the general trade system and the special trade system.

For extra-EU trade statistics, the special trade system is applied which means that goods from a non-EU country which are received into customs warehouses are not recorded in international trade statistics unless they subsequently go into free circulation in the Member State of receipt (or are placed under the customs procedures for inward processing). Similarly, outgoing goods from customs warehouses are not recorded as exports. The general trade system, which is applied by most of the EU main partner countries, is a wider concept since it includes all goods entering or leaving the country.

It should be noted that intra-EU trade statistics do not have a direct link to customs procedures, thus they are not compiled on a general or special trade basis.

A comparison of the statistics on extra-EU trade with the figures published by non-member countries for the same trade flows shows inevitably some discrepancies. Besides the trade system and errors such as misclassification, the most common reasons for discrepancies are:

- Methodological differences: trade coverage, definition of partner country, definition of statistical territory, different valuations principles;
- Time lag: the same operation can be recorded under a different reference period;
- Statistical confidentiality: the same operation cannot be recorded in the trade of one of the two partners because of statistical confidentiality;
- Different practices in the treatment of revisions;
- Problems of currency conversion.

The following Table 12 shows the mirror discrepancies in EU27 trade with its top-10 trading partners.

Table 12: Extra-EU asymmetries (in %)

Partner countries	EU27 imports*	EU27 exports**
USA	-0.2	-2.4
China	21.7	-14.0
Russia	-1.6	28.2
Switzerland	-3.5	-0.3
Norway	0.9	6.0
Japan	0.0	-12.5
Turkey	4.8	6.2
South Korea	-0.6	-6.1
Brazil	12.8	6.8
India	10.1	5.4

*: (EU imports – Mirror exports) / Mirror flows average

** : (EU exports – Mirror imports) / Mirror flows average

6.1.2 Comparability between Community concept and national concept

Community legislation serves as a basis for compiling the intra- and extra-EU trade statistics sent by the Member States and published by Eurostat. However, Community statistics, which cover the EU as a whole, and the statistics compiled and published by the Member States, are not always directly comparable. Member States may use a different concept at national level but they have to provide Eurostat with harmonised data according to the Community concept.

The most common differences between the Community concept and national concepts are as follows:

- General trade system is used at national level while the Community statistics are compiled by special trade system.
- Exclusion of "quasi-transit". Goods which are considered to be 'in transit' are included to Community statistics but may be excluded from national statistics. This involves, firstly, imports from non-member countries which are cleared in these Member States before being dispatched to other Member States and, secondly, goods from other Member States which are immediately re-exported to non-member countries. This phenomenon is sometimes referred to the 'Rotterdam effect'.
- Inclusion of repairs. Repairs are nowadays excluded from the scope of Community statistics but may be included in national statistics.
- Breakdown by partner country: For intra-EU arrivals, some Member States record the country of origin as the partner country, whereas the Member State of consignment appears in Community statistics relating to the same movements.

Table 13 shows the conceptual differences between Community statistics concept and national statistics for each Member State.

Table 13: Conceptual differences between Community statistics and national statistics

MEMBER STATES	General Trade System	Exclusion of quasi transit	Inclusion of repairs	Country of origin	Other
Belgium		*			*
Bulgaria		*		*	
Czech Republic				*	
Denmark	*	*			
Germany				*	*
Estonia					
Ireland	*		*	*	
Greece			*		
Spain	*			*	*
France				*	*
Italy					
Cyprus	*	*			
Latvia		*			
Lithuania					
Luxembourg		*	*		
Hungary		*			*
Malta	*	*		*	
Netherlands		*			
Austria		*		*	
Poland		*		*	
Portugal	*			*	
Romania					
Slovenia		*			
Slovakia		*		*	*
Finland				*	
Sweden					
United Kingdom	*	*			*

Notes:

Belgium: Returned goods are excluded from national statistics

Germany: additional statistical procedures included in national statistics

Spain: Ceuta and Melilla are included in national statistics

France: Goods delivered to vessels and aircrafts are excluded from national statistics

Hungary: Extra-EU imports at national level are by country of consignment

Slovakia: Imports are published at FOB basis

United Kingdom: Extra-EU imports at national level are by country of consignment

6.1.3 Comparability between intra-EU trade statistics based on Community concept

In theory, intra-EU trade statistics based upon Community concept should be fully comparable; therefore data should generally be less affected by asymmetries than extra-EU trade statistics. Dispatches from Member State A to Member State B, as reported by A, should be almost equal to arrivals into B from A, as reported by B. Due to a different valuation principle (CIF > FOB), arrivals should be slightly higher than dispatches (see chapter 3.2.1 for details on valuation). However, since the Intrastat system came into operation, bilateral comparisons have revealed major and persistent discrepancies in the intra-EU trade statistics. Therefore, comparisons dealing with intra-EU trade statistics have to be made cautiously and should take into account the existence of these discrepancies.

The main reasons for the discrepancies are known and are partly same as for extra-EU trade. There are also reasons which are typical for intra-EU trade such as the adjustments for non-collected data (see chapter 3.1.1) or triangular trade.

The following Table 14 reports the intra-EU asymmetries at global level and by Member States, calculated using trade in value. It is evident that the impact is very different among the Member States. Many Member States regularly carry out bilateral studies to find out at detailed product level where the problems are and to resolve them. However, remedies are not easily found despite all the analyses done.

Table 14: Intra-EU asymmetries (in %)

MEMBER STATES	Arrivals*	Dispatches**
Belgium	6.3%	7.5%
Bulgaria	6.5%	11.8%
Czech Republic	3.0%	7.4%
Denmark	2.0%	8.5%
Germany	-3.6%	0.4%
Estonia	-0.6%	9.7%
Ireland	-8.8%	-7.9%
Greece	-8.0%	-1.2%
Spain	-2.3%	2.3%
France	-3.5%	1.4%
Italy	-4.0%	4.4%
Cyprus	-19.2%	-87.2%
Latvia	-0.2%	-13.4%
Lithuania	8.8%	6.3%
Luxembourg	-5.2%	-12.7%
Hungary	1.1%	9.2%
Malta	-37.6%	-69.5%
Netherlands	-3.6%	8.9%
Austria	-1.5%	5.7%
Poland	-2.9%	7.7%
Portugal	-0.8%	6.2%
Romania	7.2%	16.0%
Slovenia	2.8%	14.4%
Slovakia	0.3%	15.8%
Finland	0.4%	-6.2%
Sweden	-1.4%	-5.1%
United Kingdom	-10.0%	-4.3%
EU-27	-2.8%	2.8%

*: (Arrivals – Mirror dispatches) / Mirror flows average

** : (Dispatches – Mirror arrivals) / Mirror flows average

6.2 Comparability over time

Comparability over time is another important aspect of quality. Changes due to definitions, coverage or methods and other changes will have an impact on the continuity of trade series.

The most important methodological changes or other events affecting the international trade statistics during the last few years are listed in the following table.

Table 15: Changes affecting comparability over time

Year	Event	Quality dimensions affected
2007	EU enlargement (accession of Bulgaria and Romania)	Relevance, accuracy, comparability
	Revision of the Harmonized System	Relevance, comparability
2006	Repairs excluded from the scope of Extrastat	Relevance, comparability
	Collection of net mass in Intrastat no longer mandatory if supplementary unit is collected	Accuracy, comparability
2005	Repairs excluded from the scope of Intrastat	Relevance, comparability
	Revised Intrastat legislation enters into force	Relevance, accuracy, timeliness, clarity, comparability
2004	EU enlargement (accession of Czech Republic, Estonia, Cyprus, Latvia, Lithuania, Hungary, Malta, Poland, Slovenia and Slovakia)	Relevance, accuracy, comparability

A particular issue of comparability over time concerns the product classifications. The most detailed statistics are collected and published by Combined Nomenclature (CN) at 8-digit level. Some changes are made to CN every year. Eurostat maintains conversion tables between the CN versions of successive years in order to improve comparison over time. The following Table 16 gives an overview on the evolution of CN codes over the last years.

Table 16: Evolution of CN codes over time

Year	Creations	Deletions	Total	Evolution	CN Codes
2008	75	96	171	-21	9699
2007	917	1039	1956	-122	9720
2006	486	740	1226	-254	9842
2005	97	175	272	-78	10096
2004	273	503	776	-230	10174
2003	19	15	34	4	10404
2002	780	654	1434	126	10400
2001	50	90	140	-40	10274

The impact of the different methodological and practical changes that have occurred in recent years is difficult to assess precisely. Nevertheless, it can be concluded that a change from an administrative data source (Extrastat) to a purely statistical data collection system (Intrastat) means normally a major break in the trade statistics time series.

6.3 Coherence with other statistics

Apart from the international trade statistics, information on trade flows can be found in National Accounts, Business Statistics and Balance of Payments. The compilation of the data and the production of the above mentioned statistics follow the recommendations (sources and methods) of different international organisations, i.e. Eurostat, International Monetary Fund (IMF), United Nations (UN), etc. Table 17 tries to give an overall idea of the main differences between these sources.

Table 17: Coherence between International Trade Statistics, National Accounts, Balance of Payments and Business Statistics at the EU level

	International Trade Statistics	National Accounts	BoP	Business Statistics
Concepts & Definitions	Community definition	Aggregation of national statistics based on ESA 95. However, account of the rest of the world is based on national definition.	Aggregation of national statistics based upon IMF 5 th manual. It implies some methodological discrepancies (FOB/FOB, difference of coverage). BoP statistics in Member States are most of the time derived from Member States' ETS. BoP statistics sent to Eurostat are compiled according to the Community concept.	Statistics are based on activity sector
Statistical unit/object/population	Cross-border movement of goods		International transaction with change of ownership	Enterprise, local unit
Classifications (nomenclature)	Combined Nomenclature (CN)	Institutional sectors	IMF classification	NACE
Geographical breakdown	Detailed geographical breakdown	Intra-EU, Extra-EU, World	Detailed geographical breakdown	All partners
Reference period	Monthly	Annual	Quarterly	Annual
Correction methods	National corrections	National corrections	National corrections	National corrections

6.4 Internal coherence

A key feature of the European trade data is its coherence. Aggregated data are constructed from detailed data over Member States and over different product classifications with the help of official correspondence tables. This ensures internal coherence. In addition, Eurostat calculates derived indicators such as unit value indices or seasonally adjusted series from the detailed data provided by Member States in order to maintain coherence.

7 Trade-offs between Output Quality Components

ESS Handbook for Quality Reports:

Output quality components are not mutually exclusive in the sense that there are relationships between the factors that contribute to them. There are cases where the factors leading to improvements with to one component result in deterioration with respect to another.

As there are a number of quality components, including some with subcomponents, the number possible pairs of trade-offs is considerable. However, not all of them are relevant for international trade statistics. Some of most significant trade-offs are considered below:

Trade-off between Relevance and Comparability over time

The most important methodological changes over time during the last few years were documented in chapter 6.2. Some changes, such as exclusion of repairs from the scope of statistics, were made in order to improve the relevance of statistics. In a similar manner, the product classifications are subject to regular revisions to ensure that they reflect changes in technology and patterns in international trade as well user needs. Consequently, comparability over time is affected.

Trade-off between Accuracy and Timeliness

Trade statistics consist of huge volume of detailed declarations collected in two different systems (Intrastat and Extrastat). As the delay to transmit detailed intra-EU trade data is considerable longer in comparison to extra-EU – 70 and 42 days, respectively - aggregated data must be reported in 40 days order to meet the macro-economic needs.

From 2010 onwards, the transmission delay of detailed extra-EU data will decrease to 40 days. No decrease in however foreseen for intra-EU trade.

Trade-off between Accuracy and Respondent Burden

Although respondent burden is not an output quality component as such, it forms an important trade-off with accuracy. Intrastat system is built in such way that smallest traders are exempted from statistical reporting (see chapter 9.2). Less data are consequently collected which affects accuracy at the most detailed level of data.

8 Assessment of User Needs and Perceptions

ESS Quality Declaration: User Focus

We provide our users with products and services that meet their needs, The articulated and non-articulated needs, demands and expectations of external and internal users will guide the ESS, its members, their employees and operations.

User needs are regularly monitored. At the EU level, there are regular contacts with key institutional users (Commission services and the European Central Bank) as well as with other main user groups such as trade associations.

In daily work, users can easily communicate their requests and needs by using common tools such as XTNET-Assist, directly integrated to Comext dissemination. The requests are further managed by the Comext helpdesk. Annually, there are almost one million extraction per year, more than 11 000 public registered users and 2500 queries.

The previous large-scale user satisfaction survey on various aspects related to data was undertaken by Eurostat in 2007. The outcome of study was that satisfaction level was very high among users; 85 % of the users were very or fairly satisfied with the data they currently use. Many Member States undertake also user satisfaction surveys regularly.

Recently, the most urgent user needs have concerned incomplete information on net mass (see chapter 3.2.2) and statistics on enterprises involved in international trade, particularly on small- and medium-sized enterprises. Concerning the former, new provisions foresee from 2010 the use of estimates if net mass is not collected directly from trade operators. Furthermore, the revised Intrastat and Extrastat Regulations introduce statistics on trade by business characteristics. These indicators will be available from reference years 2005 onwards.

9 Performance, Cost and Respondent burden

European Statistics Code of Practice

Principle 9. Resources must be effectively used.

Principle 10. Respondent burden should be proportional to the needs of users and not excessive for respondents, Respondent burden should be measured and targets set for its reduction over time.

9.1 Performance and Cost

In order to improve performance and to decrease costs caused by data collection and processing, the use of IT tools in data collection has been considered as priority. Consequently, the share of paper declarations has decreased over time. Around three quarters of all Intrastat declarations are nowadays received in electronic formats. From July 2009 onwards, no more paper declarations are allowed for exports to non-EU countries. Furthermore, several actions have undertaken to develop and promote common tools for data validation.

9.2 Respondent burden

In order to reduce the burden on enterprises, particularly small and medium sized ones, the Intrastat system is designed in a way that the workload for providers of statistical information varies according to the amount of trade in which they are engaged. To achieve this, each Member State applies a system of thresholds. Member States have to define each year thresholds for both arrivals and dispatches that exempt enterprises to provide statistical information or to limit the information collected. The thresholds are expressed in annual values of intra-EU trade. There are three types of thresholds:

- Exemption threshold. Enterprises below the exemption threshold do not have to declare at all. For defining the exemption threshold Member States have to ensure that at least 97 % of the Member State's trade value is covered.
- Simplification threshold. It allows enterprises, whose annual trade value is above the exemption threshold but below the simplification threshold, to provide only a limited set of data or use a simplified commodity code. The trade reported by these enterprises may cover for at most 6 % of the total trade. Currently three Member States apply the simplification threshold.
- Statistical value threshold. Member States may collect the statistical value of goods from part of the enterprises. The value of this trade amounts to a maximum of 70 % of the total trade of that Member State. (see chapter 3.3 for more details of statistical value)

The following tables 18 to 20 show these thresholds in value and the share of traders affected by them.

Table 18: Intrastat exemptions thresholds in EUR and share of traders exempted from reporting

MEMBER STATES	Exemption threshold in value		Share of traders exempted from reporting		
	Arrivals	Dispatches	Arrivals	Dispatches	Total
Belgium	400,000	1,000,000	92%	89%	92%
Bulgaria	76,694	153,388	:	:	:
Czech Republic	65,000	130,000	53%	62%	65%
Denmark	268,000	697,000	:	:	:
Germany	300,000	300,000	89%	79%	87%
Estonia	127,823	127,823	65%	65%	63%
Ireland	191,000	635,000	:	:	:
Greece	75,000	65,000	:	:	:
Spain	250,000	250,000	88%	81%	85%
France	150,000	150,000	76%	62%	75%
Italy	180,000	250,000	83%	71%	:
Cyprus	45,000	45,000	49%	59%	52%
Latvia	92,487	139,442	66%	68%	65%
Lithuania	130,329	159,291	63%	70%	63%
Luxembourg	150,000	150,000	91%	89%	89%
Hungary	400,000	400,000	87%	87%	86%
Malta	700	700	0%	0%	0%
Netherlands	400,000	900,000	88%	87%	93%
Austria	300,000	300,000	87%	74%	85%
Poland	128,366	205,386	42%	54%	49%
Portugal	100,000	230,000	59%	57%	58%
Romania	89,643	268,930	74%	80%	76%
Slovenia	85,000	200,000	76%	75%	75%
Slovakia	132,749	265,498	78%	78%	78%
Finland	200,000	300,000	74%	72%	74%
Sweden	238,000	484,000	78%	78%	78%
United Kingdom	385,000	385,000	81%	80%	86%

: Data not available

Table 19: Intrastat simplification thresholds in EUR and share of beneficiary PSIs

MEMBER STATES	Exemption threshold in value		Share of PSIs allowed to use Intrastat simplified declarations		
	Arrivals	Dispatches	Arrivals	Dispatches	Total
France	230 000	460 000	6%	15%	9%
Luxembourg	375 000	375 000	25%	16%	28%
Portugal	305 000	700 000	36%	36%	36%
Slovakia	637 196	1 592 991	66%	71%	76%

Table 20: Intrastat statistical value thresholds in EUR and share of beneficiary PSIs

MEMBER STATES	Statistical value threshold		Percentage of PSIs exempted from the reporting of the statistical value		
	Arrivals	Dispatches	Arrivals	Dispatches	Total
Belgium	All PSI exempted		100%	100%	100%
Bulgaria	1 534 000	3 579 000	90%	93%	90%
Czech Republic	All PSI exempted		100%	100%	100%
Denmark	All PSI exempted		100%	100%	100%
Germany	29 000 000	40 000 000	96%	96%	96%
Estonia	3 068 000	3 643 000	89%	90%	88%
Ireland	5 000 000	34 000 000	:	:	:
Greece	1 300 000	1 700 000	:	:	:
Spain	6 000 000	6 000 000	93%	91%	92%
France	All PSI exempted		100%	100%	100%
Italy	20 000 000	20 000 000	99%	97%	:
Cyprus	1 000 000	1 000 000	86%	80%	85%
Latvia	2 290 837	3 130 336	90%	89%	89%
Lithuania	2 606 580	5 502 780	86%	91%	86%
Luxembourg	2 500 000	4 500 000	86%	88%	86%
Hungary	10 000 000	40 000 000	90%	86%	87%
Malta	No exemption		0%	0%	0%
Netherlands	All PSI exempted		100%	100%	100%
Austria	6 500 000	6 500 000	86%	82%	90%
Poland	8 472 000	12 580 000	94%	93%	97%
Portugal	5 830 000	8 100 000	5%	7%	6%
Romania	2 988 000	5 976 000	88%	85%	88%
Slovenia	3 000 000	9 000 000	89%	89%	89%
Slovakia	All PSI exempted		100%	100%	100%
Finland	11 200 000	57 000 000	95%	98%	95%
Sweden	All PSI exempted		100%	100%	100%
United Kingdom	All PSI exempted		100%	100%	100%

: Data not available

In addition to thresholds in value, Member States may apply other simplification measures. These include for instance optional collection of net mass for CN-codes where quantity needs to be reported in supplementary unit or the use of simplified reporting for specific products such as industrial plants or parts of motor vehicles.

Extra-EU trade statistics cover in principle all imports and exports declared by Member States. However, it is allowed to exclude transactions whose value and net mass are lower than statistical thresholds. These thresholds are at maximum 1000 Euro or 1000 kg.

Table 21: Extrastat statistical thresholds

MEMBER STATES	Extrastat statistical threshold
Belgium	No threshold
Bulgaria	100 €
Czech Republic	No threshold
Denmark	No threshold
Germany	1000 € or 1000 kg
Estonia	No threshold
Ireland	No threshold
Greece	No threshold
Spain	No threshold
France	1000 € or 1000 kg
Italy	700 € (chapters 1-14), 1000 € (chapters 15-97)
Cyprus	No threshold
Latvia	No threshold
Lithuania	No threshold
Luxembourg	No threshold
Hungary	No threshold
Malta	No threshold
Netherlands	No threshold
Austria	1000 €
Poland	No threshold
Portugal	No threshold
Romania	No threshold
Slovenia	No threshold
Slovakia	No threshold
Finland	No threshold
Sweden	No threshold
United Kingdom	1000 € or 1000 kg

10 Confidentiality, Transparency and Security

European Statistics Code of Practice

Principle 5. The privacy of data providers (households, enterprises, administrations and other respondents), the confidentiality of the information they provide and its use only for statistical purposes must be absolutely guaranteed.

Principle 6. Statistical authorities must produce and disseminate European statistics respecting scientific independence and in an objective, professional and transparent manner in which all users are treated equitably.

In international trade statistics the principle of “passive confidentiality” is applied, by which data should be suppressed only at the request of traders who feel that their interests would be harmed by the dissemination of their data. Passive confidentiality is therefore different from “active confidentiality”, where the National Statistical Authority takes directly the initiative to suppress data automatically when the suppression criteria are met, without informing the trade operator concerned.

The considerable amount of detail in trade data means that the potential for the creation of confidential data at detailed level is extremely high. Passive confidentiality allows minimising the effect of suppression on the quality of detailed data.

The application of passive confidentiality is mentioned in both the Intrastat and Extrastat Regulations. They state also that the real trade values should be disseminated to all users at chapter level, i.e. by 2-digit codes of the product nomenclature except if the confidentiality is not thereby ensured.

After a request of the confidentiality treatment by the trader, the national statistical authority must define to which extent data provided by the trader should be considered as confidential. The national rules and practice vary between Member States from sophisticated decision making systems to case by case decisions made with common sense approach.

Data transmission from Member States to Eurostat follows the principle of a Single Entry Point (SEP), endorsed by Statistical Program Committee. Data transmission takes place with the help of eDAMIS (electronic Data files Administration and Management Information System) which is an integrated environment of data transmission tools, allowing highly secure transmission.

At Eurostat, confidential data is stored in secure environment. No access to micro data is granted for research purposes.

11 Conclusions

The previous paragraphs present the main quality indicators of the EU trade statistics for the year 2008. The purpose of this Quality Report is to provide users with information on different factors affecting statistics, thus allowing them to assess the quality. The purpose is not to sort the EU Member States from best to worst for each quality indicator; instead this report presents the differences in the practises and methods applied by Member States.

The Quality Report aims at monitoring the quality of statistics – both over time and over space - therefore it can be used as a tool to improve quality. Annual editions of the Quality Report can thus be a useful source of information also for the compilers of trade statistics at national level.

ANNEX: 2007 figures

Table 1: Share of collected data and adjustments for trade below the exemption threshold and non-response in intra-EU trade (share of total value), 2007

MEMBER STATES	Collected data				Estimated data			
	Detailed declarations		Simplified declarations		Below the exemption threshold		Non response	
	Arrivals	Dispatches	Arrivals	Dispatches	Arrivals	Dispatches	Arrivals	Dispatches
Belgium	97.4%	97.7%	0.0%	0.0%			(*) 2.6%	(*) 2.2%
Bulgaria	97.8%	98.7%	0.0%	0.0%	1.6%	1.0%	0.6%	0.3%
Czech Republic	98.7%	99.0%	0.0%	0.0%	1.0%	0.4%	0.3%	0.6%
Denmark	85.4%	91.1%	0.2%	0.1%			(*) 14.3%	(*) 8.7%
Germany	95.0%	97.1%	0.1%	0.2%	3.0%	1.8%	1.9%	1.0%
Estonia	92.1%	93.6%			3.0%	3.1%	4.9%	3.4%
Ireland	67.3%	86.6%	28.6%	11.6%	3.0%	1.5%	1.1%	0.3%
Greece **	100.0%	100.0%						
Spain **	100.0%	100.0%						
France **	98.8%	98.7%	1.2%	1.3%				
Italy	97.6%	97.7%	0.0%	0.0%	2.4%	2.3%		
Cyprus	99.0%	98.3%			1.0%	1.7%	0.0%	0.0%
Latvia	95.7%	95.2%			2.0%	2.9%	2.2%	1.9%
Lithuania	98.5%	98.6%			1.4%	1.4%	0.1%	0.0%
Luxembourg	95.1%	96.3%	3.7%	2.9%	0.6%	0.6%	0.7%	0.3%
Hungary	92.2%	93.9%	0.2%	0.0%	3.0%	2.6%	4.6%	3.5%
Malta **	100.0%	100.0%						
Netherlands	88.1%	92.8%	0.0%	0.0%	3.4%	1.7%	8.4%	5.5%
Austria	95.7%	97.3%	0.0%	0.0%	2.7%	1.2%	1.5%	1.5%
Poland	98.4%	98.5%			0.9%	0.9%	0.7%	0.6%
Portugal	96.4%	97.1%			2.4%	1.7%	1.3%	1.2%
Romania	97.1%	98.0%			2.0%	1.7%	0.9%	0.3%
Slovenia	97.7%	98.4%			2.3%	1.6%	0.0%	0.0%
Slovakia	85.4%	86.9%	9.1%	7.8%	3.4%	3.3%	2.2%	1.9%
Finland	96.6%	98.2%			2.9%	1.6%	0.5%	0.2%
Sweden	96.2%	97.7%			2.1%	1.7%	1.7%	0.6%
United Kingdom	95.9%	96.3%	0.0%	0.1%	2.5%	3.0%	1.6%	0.7%
EU-27	95.5%	96.5%	0.8%	0.6%	1.6%	1.3%	2.1%	1.6%

*: Only total level of adjustments (no distinction into below the exemption threshold and non-response) is available in Eurostat.

**: No adjustment is compiled for trade below the exemption threshold and non response.

Note: The shares of detailed and simplified declarations in EU-27 trade correspond to weighted averages. Member States' data are weighted by their respective total trade values.

Table 3: Share of collected data and adjustments for trade below the exemption threshold and late-response in extra-EU trade (share of total value), 2007

MEMBER STATES	Collected data		Estimated data			
	Standard category		Below the exemption threshold		Late/partial response	
	Imports	Exports	Imports	Exports	Imports	Exports
Belgium	100.0%	100.0%				
Bulgaria	100.0%	100.0%	0.0%	0.0%		
Czech Republic	100.0%	100.0%				
Denmark	100.0%	100.0%	0.0%			
Germany	99.8%	99.7%	0.2%	0.3%		
Estonia	100.0%	100.0%				
Ireland	100.0%	99.9%		0.1%		
Greece	100.0%	100.0%				
Spain	100.0%	100.0%				
France	99.4%	99.4%	0.6%	0.6%		
Italy	99.6%	99.2%	0.4%	0.8%		
Cyprus	100.0%	100.0%				
Latvia	100.0%	100.0%				
Lithuania	100.0%	100.0%				
Luxembourg	100.0%	100.0%				
Hungary	100.0%	100.0%				
Malta	100.0%	100.0%				
Netherlands	98.9%	98.4%			1.1%	1.6%
Austria	99.8%	99.6%	0.2%	0.4%		
Poland	100.0%	100.0%				
Portugal	100.0%	100.0%				
Romania	100.0%	100.0%				
Slovenia	99.9%	99.9%	0.1%	0.1%		
Slovakia	100.0%	100.0%				
Finland	100.0%	100.0%				
Sweden	100.0%	100.0%				
United Kingdom	98.8%	99.7%	1.2%	0.3%		
EU-27	99.5%	99.6%	0.3%	0.3%	0.1%	0.1%

Table 5: The quantitative impact of calculating the statistical value, 2007

MEMBER STATES	Arrivals	Dispatches
Belgium	No adjustment	No adjustment
Bulgaria	1.51%	-0.1%
Czech Republic	0.2%	-0.6%
Denmark	0.5%	-0.6%
Germany	0.0%	0.3%
Estonia	1.2%	-0.2%
Ireland	-0.7%	-0.9%
Greece	:	:
Spain	0.3%	0.2%
France	No adjustment	No adjustment
Italy	1.1%	0.4%
Cyprus	2.8%	-3.4%
Latvia	2.1%	-1.6%
Lithuania	1.7%	-0.2%
Luxembourg	2.2%	-2.1%
Hungary	0.4%	- 0.1%
Malta	:	:
Netherlands	:	:
Austria	0.2%	-0.4%
Poland	0.6%	-0.6%
Portugal	0.1%	-0.6%
Romania	1.0%	-0.1%
Slovenia	0.4%	-0.5%
Slovakia	0.9%	-0.3%
Finland	1.8%	-2.4%
Sweden	1.2%	-1.4%
United Kingdom	0.2%	-0.4%

: Data not available

Table 7: Impact of revisions (in %) on intra-and extra-EU trade, 2007

MEMBER STATES	Intra-EU trade		Extra-EU trade	
	Arrivals	Dispatches	Imports	Exports
Belgium	-3.3%	-2.0%	1.3%	6.7%
Bulgaria	1.4%	1.6%	0.0%	-0.3%
Czech Republic	-0.7%	-0.2%	2.9%	0.3%
Denmark	-2.0%	-1.3%	1.0%	-0.8%
Germany	-1.5%	-0.6%	1.8%	0.0%
Estonia	5.7%	1.2%	0.3%	-0.8%
Ireland	3.6%	-0.1%	-0.2%	1.2%
Greece	2.4%	1.6%	0.1%	-2.9%
Spain	8.5%	6.9%	0.6%	3.8%
France	1.7%	0.1%	3.1%	1.3%
Italy	2.8%	3.1%	-0.3%	-0.5%
Cyprus	1.2%	0.5%	9.9%	0.1%
Latvia	2.9%	2.4%	0.0%	0.0%
Lithuania	3.1%	0.1%	0.1%	-0.3%
Luxembourg	3.6%	1.3%	3.4%	7.4%
Hungary	1.1%	2.2%	0.9%	3.1%
Malta	10.2%	5.3%	6.7%	6.0%
Netherlands	-0.2%	0.2%	1.3%	0.0%
Austria	6.1%	6.2%	3.8%	-0.3%
Poland	9.5%	5.5%	0.6%	0.3%
Portugal	2.5%	2.7%	1.5%	1.5%
Romania	1.4%	1.3%	2.7%	-0.9%
Slovenia	1.3%	0.3%	0.9%	-0.2%
Slovakia	-0.7%	0.6%	1.0%	-0.7%
Finland	4.1%	1.2%	0.6%	2.9%
Sweden	2.2%	0.1%	3.8%	1.3%
United Kingdom	3.4%	2.3%	-0.4%	1.4%
EU-27	1.5%	0.9%	1.1%	0.9%

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Table 8: Impact of the confidentiality on intra- and extra-EU trade, 2007

MEMBER STATES	Intra-EU trade						Extra-EU trade					
	Arrivals			Dispatches			Imports			Exports		
	Number of CN8 codes affected	Impact on trade value (%)	Impact on net mass (%)	Number of CN8 codes affected	Impact on trade value (%)	Impact on net mass (%)	Number of CN8 codes affected	Impact on trade value (%)	Impact on net mass (%)	Number of CN8 codes affected	Impact on trade value (%)	Impact on net mass (%)
Belgium	34	0.8%	0.2%	144	1.9%	2.6%	34	1.5%	0.4%	137	3.1%	4.6%
Bulgaria	20	0.0%	0.0%	7	1.7%	0.0%	19	35.1%	0.0%	13	2.0%	0.0%
Czech	774	0.4%		312	0.5%		312	0.3%		243	0.7%	
Denmark	36	0.6%	1.7%	97	9.1%	4.8%	31	3.1%	1.5%	96	11.6%	12.8%
Germany	61	1.7%	5.9%	417	3.1%	6.8%	53	6.1%	23.5%	405	3.5%	10.5%
Estonia												
Ireland	15	0.0%	0.0%	8	0.1%	0.5%						
Greece	12	0.2%	0.0%	13	3.9%	0.9%	12	0.0%	0.0%	16	2.1%	0.3%
Spain	35	0.1%	0.4%	29	0.5%	0.9%	31	0.3%	0.2%	35	1.1%	1.2%
France	12	0.0%	0.0%	300	2.5%	4.6%	10	0.0%	5.5%	278	2.0%	4.6%
Italy	26	1.3%	0.2%	116	0.7%	1.3%	24	9.0%	16.9%	106	0.5%	1.1%
Cyprus	1	0.1%	0.0%				1	0.6%	0.0%	1	0.0%	0.0%
Latvia												
Lithuania												
Luxembourg	3	3.9%	6.0%	7	1.2%	0.9%	1	1.2%	0.8%	5	2.4%	0.1%
Hungary	1 547	3.0%	7.8%	1 963	5.3%	19.7%	602	12.5%	41.7%	1 754	5.7%	18.7%
Malta												
Netherlands	245	4.2%	1.4%	509	6.2%	1.8%	462	3.5%	2.8%	915	2.4%	2.3%
Austria	96	2.5%	9.3%	283	7.7%	11.6%	89	13.8%	42.9%	274	6.8%	7.0%
Poland	1	0.0%	0.0%									
Portugal	3 771	1.3%	1.3%	1 522	5.3%	8.1%	1 424	1.8%	1.6%	1 114	3.9%	5.0%
Romania	88	0.2%	0.0%	50	0.2%	0.0%	74	0.3%	0.0%	40	0.5%	0.0%
Slovenia	23	0.0%	0.0%	12	0.0%	0.1%	20		0.0%	21	0.2%	0.8%
Slovakia	1 018	0.3%		1 651	1.5%		97	0.1%		323	0.2%	
Finland	70	1.1%	10.6%	140	6.9%	14.0%	61	4.8%	11.3%	131	5.7%	12.9%
Sweden	18	0.1%	0.1%	83	3.7%	1.5%	18	0.5%	1.3%	82	4.5%	2.5%
United	20	0.1%	1.7%	79	1.1%	2.3%	34	0.2%	0.5%	76	0.8%	1.9%

Table 9: Impact of different type of confidentiality on intra- and extra-EU trade (share of total value), 2007

MEMBER STATES	Intra-EU trade (%)						Extra-EU trade (%)					
	Arrivals			Dispatches			Imports			Exports		
	Secret product	Secret partner	Product and partner	Secret product	Secret partner	Product and partner	Secret product	Secret partner	Product and partner	Secret product	Secret partner	Product and partner
Belgium	0.8%			1.9%			1.5%		0.0%	3.0%		0.1%
Bulgaria		0.0%			1.7%			35.1%			2.0%	
Czech Republic	0.4%		0.0%	0.5%		0.0%	0.3%		0.1%	0.5%		0.2%
Denmark	0.2%	0.4%		4.0%	5.0%		2.8%	0.2%		2.4%	9.2%	
Germany	0.1%	1.5%	0.2%	1.4%	0.4%	1.3%	0.1%	5.9%	0.1%	1.7%	0.2%	1.6%
Estonia												
Ireland			0.0%			0.1%						
Greece	0.2%			3.9%			0.0%			2.1%		
Spain	0.1%			0.5%			0.3%			1.1%		
France	0.0%	0.0%		2.4%	0.0%	0.1%	0.0%	0.0%		1.9%	0.0%	0.0%
Italy			1.3%			0.7%			9.0%			0.5%
Cyprus			0.1%						0.6%			0.0%
Latvia												
Lithuania												
Luxembourg			3.9%			1.2%			1.2%			2.4%
Hungary	3.0%			5.3%			12.5%			5.7%		
Malta												
Netherlands	3.6%	0.3%	0.3%	4.5%	0.4%	1.3%	0.2%	1.0%	2.3%	1.2%	0.9%	0.3%
Austria	0.4%		2.1%	2.6%		5.1%	1.5%	12.3%		3.7%	3.1%	
Poland		0.0%										
Portugal	0.8%		0.5%	2.3%		3.1%	0.3%		1.5%	0.4%		3.6%
Romania	0.2%			0.2%			0.3%			0.5%		
Slovenia			0.0%			0.0%						0.2%
Slovakia	0.3%			1.5%			0.1%	0.0%		0.2%		
Finland		0.3%	0.8%		2.2%	4.7%		0.1%	4.7%		1.7%	4.0%
Sweden			0.1%			3.7%			0.5%			4.5%
United Kingdom	0.1%	0.1%		1.0%	0.1%		0.1%	0.2%		0.6%	0.2%	

Table 10: Number of CN8 codes affected according to the type of confidentiality, 2007

MEMBER STATES	Intra-EU trade (%)						Extra-EU trade (%)					
	Arrivals			Dispatches			Imports			Exports		
	Secret product	Secret partner	Product and partner	Secret product	Secret partner	Product and partner	Secret product	Secret partner	Product and partner	Secret product	Secret partner	Product and partner
Belgium	34			144			28		6	129		8
Bulgaria		1	19		2	5		2	17		2	11
Czech Republic	765		9	304		8	306		6	235		8
Denmark	21	15		51	46		18	13		50	46	
Germany	6	38	17	125	67	225	6	29	18	124	58	223
Estonia												
Ireland			15			8						
Greece	12			13			12			16		
Spain	35			29			31			35		
France	5	7		294	4	2	3	7		273	3	2
Italy			26			116			24			106
Cyprus			1						1			1
Latvia												
Lithuania												
Luxembourg			3			7			1			5
Hungary	1 547			1 963			602			1 754		
Malta												
Netherlands	85	146	14	211	276	22	62	384	16	152	738	25
Austria	40		56	169		114	35	54		162	112	
Poland		1										
Portugal	2 125		1 646	724		798	506		918	208		906
Romania	88			50			74			40		
Slovenia		1	22			12		1	19			21
Slovakia	1 018			1 651			96	1		323		
Finland		38	32		13	127		34	27		12	119
Sweden			18			83			18			82
United Kingdom	11	9		62	17		9	25		47	29	

Table 11: Transmission of detailed and aggregated results, 2007

MEMBER STATES	Aggregated data		Detailed data			
	Intra- and extra-EU trade		Intra-EU trade		Extra-EU trade	
	Number of delayed data deliveries	Average delay in number	Number of delayed data deliveries	Average delay in number	Number of delayed data deliveries	Average delay in number
Belgium	1	1 day(s)	1	2 day(s)	3	1 day(s)
Bulgaria						
Czech Republic	1	3 day(s)				
Denmark			1	1 day(s)		
Germany	1	1 day(s)				
Estonia	1	1 day(s)	1	4 day(s)		
Ireland						
Greece	2	9 day(s)			2	7 day(s)
Spain	2	9 day(s)			2	3 day(s)
France	1	1 day(s)				
Italy	(*) 1	(*) 7	1	1 day(s)	2	8 day(s)
Cyprus	2	1 day(s)	2	3 day(s)	3	2 day(s)
Latvia	1	1 day(s)			2	1 day(s)
Lithuania						
Luxembourg					4	2 day(s)
Hungary						
Malta	2	3 day(s)			2	1 day(s)
Netherlands						
Austria						
Poland						
Portugal	2	2 day(s)	1	1 day(s)	2	1 day(s)
Romania			1	1 day(s)	1	1 day(s)
Slovenia	1	1 day(s)	1	1 day(s)	1	5 day(s)
Slovakia	1	10 day(s)			1	1 day(s)
Finland						
Sweden						
United					3	1 day(s)

*: Delays related to the transmission of intra-EU aggregated data only. Extra-EU aggregated data have been delivered systematically in due time

Table 14: Intra-EU27 asymmetries (in %), 2007

MEMBER STATES	Arrivals*	Dispatches**
Belgium	4.2%	6.2%
Bulgaria	12.5%	13.2%
Czech Republic	2.2%	7.9%
Denmark	2.5%	8.8%
Germany	-1.7%	1.1%
Estonia	-1.3%	-0.3%
Ireland	-11.1%	-11.3%
Greece	-8.1%	-5.6%
Spain	-5.7%	1.3%
France	-3.9%	1.4%
Italy	-2.6%	7.1%
Cyprus	-18.3%	-105.8%
Latvia	-1.4%	-17.5%
Lithuania	8.8%	8.5%
Luxembourg	-5.1%	-7.5%
Hungary	-0.1%	6.5%
Malta	-23.4%	-23.7%
Netherlands	-3.9%	5.9%
Austria	-1.3%	6.0%
Poland	-5.3%	7.1%
Portugal	-1.8%	10.2%
Romania	11.8%	13.1%
Slovenia	1.8%	14.9%
Slovakia	1.6%	12.7%
Finland	-2.2%	-6.0%
Sweden	-2.7%	-4.0%
United Kingdom	-5.2%	-2.5%
EU-27	-2.6%	2.6%

*: (Arrivals – Mirror dispatches) / Mirror flows average

**: (Dispatches – Mirror arrivals) / Mirror flows average

Table 18: Intrastat exemptions thresholds in EUR and share of traders exempted from reporting, 2007

MEMBER STATES	Exemption threshold in value		Share of traders exempted from reporting		
	Arrivals	Dispatches	Arrivals	Dispatches	Total
Belgium	400 000	1 000 000	92%	89%	92%
Bulgaria	76 694	51 129	:	:	:
Czech Republic	65 000	130 000	53%	62%	65%
Denmark	242 000	630 000	78%	78%	80%
Germany	300 000	300 000	90%	79%	87%
Estonia	127 823	127 823	63%	64%	62%
Ireland	191 000	635 000	97%	95%	97%
Greece	55 000	55 000	39%	27%	36%
Spain	200 000	200 000	83%	74%	80%
France	150 000	150 000	76%	63%	75%
Italy	180 000	250 000	84%	71%	:
Cyprus	52 147	52 147	47%	57%	50%
Latvia	69 721	115 253	66%	69%	64%
Lithuania	72 405	101 367	55%	65%	55%
Luxembourg	150 000	150 000	91%	89%	89%
Hungary	240 000	400 000	80%	84%	81%
Malta	700	700	0%	0%	0%
Netherlands	400 000	400 000	85%	80%	91%
Austria	300 000	300 000	86%	77%	84%
Poland	127 166	203 626	50%	56%	58%
Portugal	70 000	110 000	95%	93%	95%
Romania	85 000	250 000	69%	77%	71%
Slovenia	85 000	200 000	74%	73%	73%
Slovakia	132 749	265 498	77%	79%	77%
Finland	100 000	200 000	71%	70%	71%
Sweden	238 000	484 000	79%	79%	79%
United Kingdom	385 000	385 000	82%	83%	82%

: Data not available

Table 19: Intrastat simplification thresholds in EUR and share of beneficiary PSIs, 2007

MEMBER STATES	Exemption threshold in value		Share of PSIs allowed to use Intrastat simplified declarations		
	Arrivals	Dispatches	Arrivals	Dispatches	Total
France	230 000	460 000	7%	15%	10%
Luxembourg	375 000	375 000	26%	15%	29%
Slovakia	637 196	637 196	66%	72%	76%

Table 20: Intrastat statistical value thresholds in EUR and share of beneficiary PSIs, 2007

MEMBER STATES	Statistical value threshold		Percentage of PSIs exempted from the reporting of the statistical value		
	Arrivals	Dispatches	Arrivals	Dispatches	Total
Belgium	All PSIs exempted		100%	100%	100%
Bulgaria	1 023 000	3 068 000	86%	92%	87%
Czech Republic	All PSIs exempted		100%	100%	100%
Denmark	All PSIs exempted		100%	100%	100%
Germany	25 000 000	37 000 000	96%	97%	96%
Estonia	3 067 759	3 642 964	89%	91%	89%
Ireland	5 000 000	34 000 000	90%	77%	90%
Greece	(*) 1 300 000	(*) 1 700 000	:	:	:
Spain	6 000 000	6 000 000	91%	90%	91%
France	All PSIs exempted		100%	100%	100%
Italy	20 000 000	20 000 000	99%	97%	:
Cyprus	869 000	869 000	84%	79%	83%
Latvia	1 750 142	2 852 874	90%	88%	90%
Lithuania	2 027 340	5 792 400	86%	93%	87%
Luxembourg	2 500 000	4 500 000	86%	89%	86%
Hungary	10 000 000	40 000 000	91%	82%	88%
Malta	No exemption		0%	0%	0%
Netherlands	All PSIs exempted		100%	100%	100%
Austria	6 500 000	6 500 000	86%	82%	90%
Poland	7 381 436	12 472 081	93%	94%	96%
Portugal	5 830 000	8 100 000	95%	93%	94%
Romania	2 800 000	5 600 000	89%	87%	89%
Slovenia	3 000 000	9 000 000	91%	91%	91%
Slovakia	All PSIs exempted		100%	100%	100%
Finland	13 200 000	51 800 000	96%	98%	96%
Sweden	All PSIs exempted		100%	100%	100%
United Kingdom	All PSIs exempted		100%	100%	100%

: Data not available

*: All the traders report the statistical value including those above the statistical value threshold.

Table 21: Extrastat statistical thresholds, 2007

MEMBER STATES	Extrastat statistical threshold
Belgium	No threshold
Bulgaria	100 €
Czech Republic	No threshold
Denmark	No threshold
Germany	1000 € or 1000 kg
Estonia	No threshold
Ireland	No threshold
Greece	No threshold
Spain	No threshold
France	1000 € or 1000 kg
Italy	700 € (chapters 1-14), 1000 € (chapters 15-97)
Cyprus	No threshold
Latvia	No threshold
Lithuania	No threshold
Luxembourg	No threshold
Hungary	No threshold
Malta	No threshold
Netherlands	No threshold
Austria	1000 €
Poland	No threshold
Portugal	No threshold
Romania	No threshold
Slovenia	No threshold
Slovakia	No threshold
Finland	No threshold
Sweden	No threshold
United Kingdom	1000 € or 1000 kg

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